

One of the most meaningful things I learned in this course was the concept of Traditional Ecological Knowledge (TEK). As I worked through the material, it became clear that TEK is not just something anthropology studies, it actually reflects the discipline's entire approach. TEK is a microcosm of anthropology because it brings together knowledge about the environment, culture, values, social life, and spiritual beliefs. It helped me understand how anthropology works holistically, always looking at the big picture and the relationships between different parts of life.

Before this class, I mostly thought about environmental change through data, policy, and scientific research. Learning about TEK gave me a different perspective. It showed me that knowledge also exists in communities that have lived closely with the land for generations. TEK isn't just practical information about the weather or animal behavior—it includes cultural traditions, ethical relationships with the environment, and a long history of observation and adaptation passed down through lived experience.

This connection between TEK and anthropology's values was something I noticed when going back through the beginning of the course (Brightspace Module 1). Anthropologists don't just look at one part of life. They try to understand how everything is connected. That's exactly what TEK does. In *Through the Lens of Anthropology*, TEK is described as a deeply integrated knowledge system that includes environmental understanding, tools and technology, social relationships, and cultural meaning (Muckle & González, 2020). It's not broken into categories like Western science often does. Instead, it reflects the same holistic logic anthropology tries to follow.

In Module 13, the environmental anthropology material emphasized that people who are deeply connected to their surroundings are often the first to notice environmental changes. These observations are not random or purely instinctual. They are based on generations of careful attention and shared knowledge. In the *Sila Alangotok* teacher's guide, I was introduced to Inuit Qaujimajatuqangit (IQ), the Inuit term for traditional knowledge. IQ goes beyond technical skill or survival—it includes language, ethics, spiritual beliefs, and community values (Sutherland & Ashford, 2003). That complexity reminded me that TEK is anthropology in action: it does not separate people from their environment or culture from knowledge. Everything is linked.

Seeing TEK in this way helped me understand what anthropology is really about. It's not just about studying other people—it's about understanding the full context of how people live, think, and relate to the world. TEK taught me that knowledge can be emotional, spiritual, and relational, and that all of those things matter. More than anything, it showed me that anthropology isn't just about asking questions—it's about asking questions that are aware of the cultural lens they come from, and that respect the cultural context of the people they seek to understand.